The Cult

By Jon Stewart

ME: **(PG 81-92)** *(to audience)* Considering the many feats of leadership in the twentieth century, from Churchill's morale-rallying speeches in World War II to Martin Luther King Jr.'s marches for racial equality during the sixties, the ones that I find most impressive are the Jonestown Massacre and Heaven's Gate. While Churchill and King inspired loyalty and devotion, they had the benefit of real issues and problems to play on. Getting people to buckle down during World War II or walk a couple of blocks with you on a sunny day in Alabama are impressive indeed, but getting people to kill themselves for no reason other than you think you saw something about it in a dream? *(makes an impressed and wonder-filled "humph")*

Me . . . persuasive leader of a messianic cult? Would I have the strength? Would I be able to overcome my fear of death, zealous crowds and death by zealous crowds? Would I understand the intricacies of forming a tax-exempt organization?

INTRODUCTION

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ME: *(to audience)* We begin in the back room of my cult's compound – also known as my rent-controlled one-bedroom. My subjects have congregated on this day to witness our salvation. I have foretold a vision of the Rapture. At 4:00 P.M., Captain Crunch will spring to life from his resting place on the back of a cereal box and deliver us to our eternal bliss. It is 3:56 P.M.

LT JOHNSON: Leader . . . What a glorious day for our deliverance!

ME: *(distracted by the time)* Yes, yes. The day is glorious, although they say tomorrow's pollen count will be moderate to heavy.

LT JOHNSON: What care we of tomorrow, when salvation is but four minutes away.

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ME: I'm just saying I would hate to go to our salvation with red itching eyes.

LT MCSHANE: But the Captain will deliver us from our earthly afflictions. You said!

LT JOHNSON: He knows what he said. Why must you always nag? He knows we --

ME: Fellas, please. With the air conditioning out, the last thing I need is the two of you making a ruckus.

LIEUTENANT JOHNSON: Tell us again, for the last time, the story of Captain.

ME: All right. But then you both have to finish unloading the dishwasher like I asked you yesterday.

LT JOHNSON: We're sorry, Leader. We just thought that with the Captain coming . . .

LT MCSHANE: We would have no more use for earthly dishes.

ME: So you want the Captain to eat off dirty dishes. Our savior of saviors, and you can't take the time?

LT MCSHANE: Were sorry, Leader. Please forgive our sinful ways. *(They begin to kiss his feet)*

ME: All right, fine . . . get up. C'mon. You're embarrassing me, you . . . *(they get up)* Anyhoo. *(preaching)* The Captain was an all-powerful, benevolent leader. His people lived in a state of constant bliss, with a little sugar rush thrown in for good measure. One day, while his followers were being sinful and lazy and arguing with each other, a mean leprechaun accused the Captain of stealing his Lucky Charms. The leprechaun put a spell on the Captain, confining him until the righteous among us could pull the sword from the rock, showing the Captain we were worthy of receiving his good graces.

LT JOHNSON: Leader? I have a question. If the Captain is all-powerful . . . How could the leprechaun put a spell on him?

LT MCSHANE: And what of the sword? I mean, I don't want to nitpick, but you never mentioned the sword before.

ME: You're gonna do this now? Huh? Three . . . two minutes to salvation and you're gonna do this now? Maybe you guys should have thought of this before you signed up, because if you're gonna nitpick, I got a living room filled with believers that would love to be lieutenants. Remember, at Salvation, the lieutenants get to carry the Captain's hat.

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LT MCSHANE: No, Leader. Please don't be angry. It's just . . . I had never heard that thing about the sword before.

ME: Well, I just remembered it. Besides, you had no trouble swallowing the cereal box come to life part.

LT MCSHANE: That's true.

LT JOHNSON: And when the Captain comes he will relieve our earthly afflictions?

ME: Bingo.

LT JOHNSON: This cursed cleft chin will finally be gone.

ME: I keep telling you. That's considered a positive feature.

LT MCSHANE: And what of my leprosy?

ME: Your what? I thought that was dermatitis.

LT MCSHANE: *(Showing his arms)* This is dermatitis. *(Lifting up his shirt)* This is leprosy.

ME: Oh, my God *(furiously rubbing his exposed skin).* I hugged you in the Circle of Knowledge yesterday! Please get off the chair, nothing personal. I just had them redone and it cost a fortune . . . and I'll take the drinking glass, please . . . thank you.

OTHER ROOM: *(From the other room a group chant begins.)* CAPTAIN, WE ARE READY. 10 – 9 – 8. . .

ME: My watch still says 3:58. Imitation Rolex. *(bangs watch on the table and puts it to his ear)*

LT JOHNSON: Come, Leader, let us join the others so the Captain will see our solidarity.

ME: You guys go. I still have that . . . thing . . . in the oven. Wouldn't want the Captain's chicken to get dry.

LT MCSHANE: All right. See you in Nirvana. *(They exit)*

OTHER ROOM: *(The chant goes on)* 3 – 2 – 1 . . . *(Then all is silent. The silence endures ... and then the Lieutenants re-enter the room)*

LT JOHNSON: Uhh, Leader . . . can we have a word with you, please?

ME: Huh. Oh! Hey, how's the Captain?

LT MCSHANE: Everyone would like a word with you in the front . . . now.

ME: Sure, sure. *(he is dragged into the front room)* Hey, everybody! What can I do you for?

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FOLLOWER #1: It is 4:02. And still the Captain remains on the box. Smirking at us.

ME: 4:02. Right. *(frantically thinking of an explanation)* Right . . . Oh my God. It's Daylight Saving Time, isn't it? In the Land of Plenty it's still 3:02. Silly mistake. I can't believe I --

FOLLOWER #1: You lied to us, Leader. You took advantage of us.

ME: Now let's not start hurling accusations. I mean, who among us can really cast the first stone? Lying, taking advantage. Those are serious allega . . . *(A clamor arises from the followers)* All right now, settle down, people. Remember, I'm still the one making up the seating chart for the rocket ship *(They quiet)* Heh, heh. Well. *(beat)* Are we out of onion dip? Let me run out and grab some quick, because the Captain's going to be here in about *(checking watch)* fifty-five minutes and you know he'll be hungry and . . . *(They surround him ominously)* Hey, c'mon. Why the long faces? The Captain's a little late. Christ. The guy's been on a box for . . .

FOLLOWER #3: You took all I had in the world. You destroyed my family. All I did was ask you for directions and before I knew what hit me, you had ruined me with your lies of a promised land of Crunchberries and honey . . .

FOLLOWER #4: Get him!! *(General mayhem ensues. Lamps break, feelings are hurt.)*

ME: People, please! Settle down! Now listen. I know you're disappointed that the Captain didn't show us the way to eternal salvation, but we still have cable till the end of the month, so let's show a little restraint here.

LT JOHNSON: Perhaps the Captain knew there were skeptics among us. Perhaps this is why he has forsaken us.

ME: Boom! Exactly. Couldn't have put it better myself. Damn skeptics. Maybe if you people hadn't balked at the bathroom tax none of this would . . .

LT MCSHANE: A suicide pact will convince the Captain of our sincerity. A suicide pact led by our leader. The Leader will die and we shall follow!

ME: Whoa. Whoa. Slow down there, chief. I mean, suicide . . . we could get in a lot of trouble for that.

LT JOHNSON: Suicide is the only Way!

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ME: You never heard of a letter-writing campaign? Stop. This is madness! *(The crowd hushes at his fervor)*

FOLLOWER #1: You're stalling.

FOLLOWER #2: You're a staller and a liar.

ME: Look. You're all really mad at me, but . . . You wanted this. You needed this. It was your weakness that made this all possible. You didn't want to take responsibility for your own lives. You had to look to a savior to make it all better for you. I didn't do this to you, you did it to yourselves. You wanted to believe in an easy solution to the complex stresses and anxieties of your lives. I saved you from yourselves. *(All is quiet in the room, then a warlike shriek goes up and the mob attacks)*

Wait! Stop! Ow! Don't pull, it's not a toupee! . . . *(suddenly pointing to the cereal box)* Oh my God! It's THE CAPTAIN! *(The room goes silent as all eyes shift to the cereal box – a long beat; then he speaks with conviction)* See? Do you see! The Captain hasn't moved, but for that one brief moment, we all believed again. We all believed in the possibility of our salvation. *(Heads nodding, the believers are contemplating – He begins to back away toward the exit)* Remember those days. The believing days. Those were good times. . . *(He runs out with the crowd in hot pursuit)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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